Russia Lets an American Teacher Go Home

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Russia has freed Stephen Hubbard, a 74-year-old American. Russian President Vladimir Putin said he let Hubbard go after President Trump asked.

Hubbard used to be a school teacher in Michigan. Russian soldiers caught him in Ukraine in 2022. In 2024, a Russian **court** said he had fought for Ukraine's army and gave him nearly seven years in **prison**. The United States said he was being held **unfairly**.

Putin shared the news while meeting Steve Witkoff, a helper sent by the White House. They talked about a plan to end the **war** in Ukraine.

President Trump wrote, "Welcome home Stephen." He said the U.S. did not give Russia anything in return. Hubbard's son thanked both leaders.

Some Ukrainians were upset because Witkoff praised Putin, the leader they blame for the **war**. Russia also said new **peace talks** could start in mid-November.

Word Treasure

prison -- A prison is a place where people are locked up as punishment.

court -- A court is a place where judges decide legal cases.

unfairly -- Unfairly means in a way that is not right or just.

peace talks -- Peace talks are meetings where sides in a fight try to agree to stop it.

war -- A war is a long fight between countries or large groups using armies.

Background you need

Russia and Ukraine are neighbor countries that have been at war since 2022.

When a country holds a foreign person in prison, that person's home country often sends helpers to talk and bring them home.

The United States is trying to help Russia and Ukraine start peace talks.

Break it down

WHO: Russian President Vladimir Putin, President Trump and Stephen Hubbard, a 74-year-old former teacher from Michigan

WHAT: Russia freed Hubbard from prison after President Trump asked

WHERE: Russia, where Putin met White House helper Steve Witkoff

WHY: Putin let Hubbard go after a request from Trump, during talks about ending the war in Ukraine

Why it matters

It shows how leaders can work together to bring a person home to his family.

Test what you remember

1. How old is Stephen Hubbard?

- (A) 84
- (B) 64
- (C) 74
- (D) 47

2. What job did Hubbard used to have?

- (A) School teacher
- (B) Pilot
- (C) Doctor
- (D) Farmer

3. Who asked Russia to let Hubbard go?

- (A) Hubbard's teacher
- (B) Ukraine's army
- (C) President Trump
- (D) The King of England

4. Where was Hubbard caught in 2022?

- (A) France
- (B) Michigan
- (C) Ukraine
- (D) China

5. What did the U.S. give Russia in return?

- (A) A plane
- (B) Nothing
- (C) Oil
- (D) Money

6. When could new peace talks start?

- (A) Next summer
- (B) In 2030
- (C) Last week
- (D) Mid-November

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: C 4: C 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. President Trump: Welcomed Hubbard home and said the U.S. gave nothing in return.
2. Hubbard's son: Thanked both leaders.
3. Some Ukrainians: Were upset that Witkoff praised Putin.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):